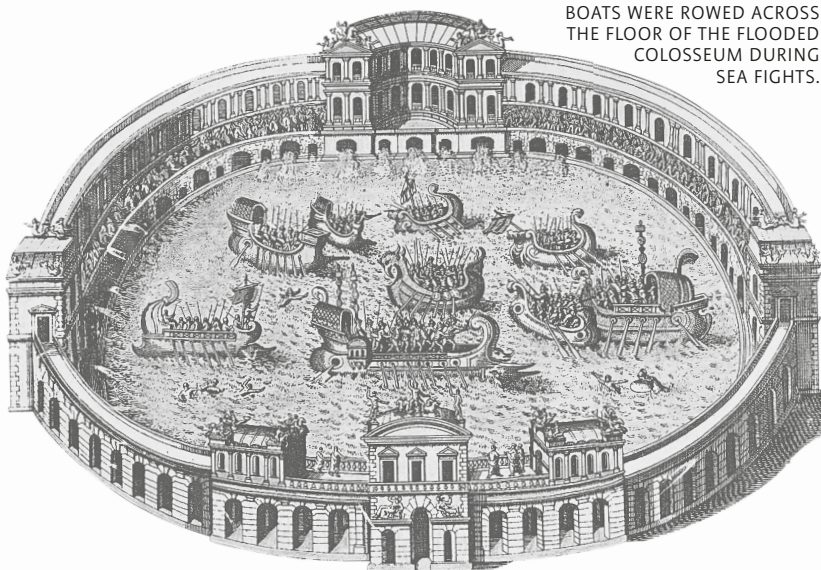


BOATS WERE ROWED ACROSS
THE FLOOR OF THE FLOODED
COLOSSEUM DURING
SEA FIGHTS.



called the *velarium*, was operated by sailors. They were used to working with ships' ropes and canvas sails—the same materials that the *velarium* was made from.

Naval battles were so popular, they were moved to a lake by the River Tiber. Then a network of passages was dug beneath the arena. In this

THE ENTIRE COLOSSEUM COULD BE EVACUATED IN 3 MINUTES.

Sea fights in the city

When the Colosseum was first built, it was possible to flood the floor of the arena, because the ground beneath was solid and water did not leak away. If you'd been in the crowd at one of the early games, you might have seen a sea fight, when gladiators fought on the decks of ships that floated on this artificial lake.

gloomy underworld, animals were kept in pens, ready to be sent up to their slaughter. Other parts of this hot, noisy labyrinth housed gladiators—the stars of the show who were about to have their moment of glory or disaster. For beasts and gladiators alike, there was no turning back. It was time to entertain the excited crowd, who were baying for blood!